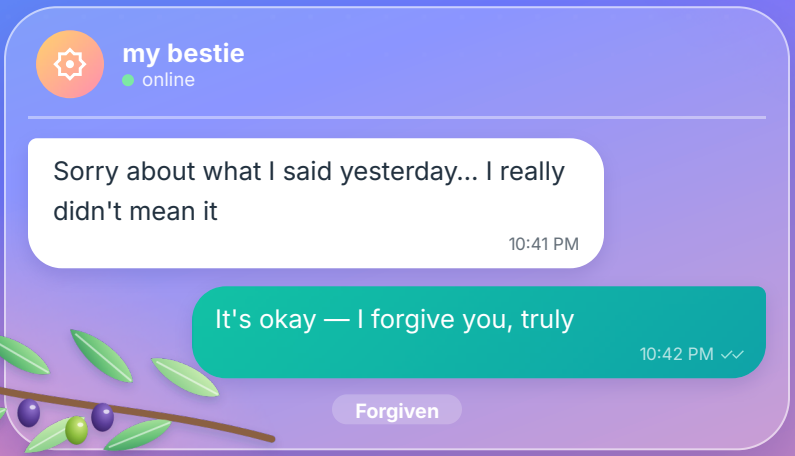
AN INTERACTIVE BOOKLET ON FORGIVENESS

# I Forgive, I Rise

For Grade 9 students




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INTRODUCTION

# Before You Begin

**Dear student,**

We all go through moments that hurt: a harsh word, a secret shared, a friend who lets us down when we need her most. Each time, we face two choices: carry it with us for days, or set it down and move on.

This booklet is about the second choice, and why it takes strength, not weakness.

### The branch journey

At the bottom of every page there is a small olive branch. Watch it stretch and grow leaves page by page until it bears fruit at the end of the booklet — the way forgiveness grows in us when we keep tending it.

## Inside this booklet


What is forgiveness? 3
Why is forgiveness beautiful? 4
Forgiveness in the Qur'an 5
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FILE 01

# What Is Forgiveness?

**In Arabic:** *tasāmuḥ* comes from *samāḥa*: ease and gentleness.

**In everyday life:** letting go of the wish to get even with someone who hurt you, and treating them gently — while still protecting your rights and your self-respect.

### ʿAfw • العفو

Pardoning: not holding the mistake against someone.

### Ṣafḥ • الصفح

Overlooking: letting go of blame and reproach too — a deeper step than pardon.

### Taghaful • التغافل

Graceful blindness: noticing a small slip and choosing to let it pass.

## Myth or fact?

| MYTH | FACT |
| --- | --- |
| ~~Forgiving is weak.~~ | Holding anger back is harder than letting it out — that is strength. |
| ~~Forgiving means forgetting.~~ | You remember what happened; it just stops controlling you. |
| ~~Forgiving means trusting again right away.~~ | Forgiveness can be given at once; trust is rebuilt step by step. |
| ~~Forgiving means staying silent about wrong.~~ | You can ask for your rights politely, then choose to pardon. |

FILE 02

# Why Is Forgiveness Beautiful?

### It brings me closer to Allah

Whoever pardons others hopes for Allah's pardon: “Would you not like that Allah should forgive you?”

### It frees my heart

Built-up anger wears you down; forgiveness lifts that weight.

### It protects my friendships

No friendship is free of mistakes; forgiveness is what keeps it going.

### It shows my strength

Self-control in anger is harder than reacting — that is why it is a sign of strength.

### It builds a safe space

In a class where forgiveness is common, conflicts shrink and everyone feels free to speak up.

*Pardoning when you are able to punish is a mark of the noble.*

Arabic proverb

FILE 03

# Forgiveness in the Qur'an

﴿الَّذِينَ يُنفِقُونَ فِي السَّرَّاءِ وَالضَّرَّاءِ وَالْكَاظِمِينَ الْغَيْظَ وَالْعَافِينَ عَنِ النَّاسِ ۗ وَاللَّهُ يُحِبُّ الْمُحْسِنِينَ﴾

***"...who restrain anger and who pardon the people — and Allah loves the doers of good."*** *[Al ʿImrān 3:134]*

**Insight:** Three levels: hold back anger, pardon, then do good.

﴿ادْفَعْ بِالَّتِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ فَإِذَا الَّذِي بَيْنَكَ وَبَيْنَهُ عَدَاوَةٌ كَأَنَّهُ وَلِيٌّ حَمِيمٌ﴾

***"Repel [evil] by that [deed] which is better; and thereupon the one whom between you and him is enmity [will become] as though he was a devoted friend."*** *[Fuṣṣilat 41:34]*

**Insight:** Kindness can turn an opponent into a close friend.

﴿خُذِ الْعَفْوَ وَأْمُرْ بِالْعُرْفِ وَأَعْرِضْ عَنِ الْجَاهِلِينَ﴾

***"Take what is given freely, enjoin what is good, and turn away from the ignorant."*** *[Al-Aʿraf 7:199]*

**Insight:** Not every provocation deserves a reply.

﴿وَجَزَاءُ سَيِّئَةٍ سَيِّئَةٌ مِّثْلُهَا ۖ فَمَنْ عَفَا وَأَصْلَحَ فَأَجْرُهُ عَلَى اللَّهِ﴾

***"And the retribution for an evil act is an evil one like it, but whoever pardons and makes reconciliation — his reward is [due] from Allah."*** *[Ash-Shūrā 42:40]*

**Insight:** Answering in kind is fair; pardoning is higher, and its reward is with Allah.

Translation of meanings: Saheeh International.

FILE 04

# Forgiveness in the Sunnah

## The Prophet ﷺ said:

«لَيْسَ الشَّدِيدُ بِالصُّرَعَةِ، إِنَّمَا الشَّدِيدُ الَّذِي يَمْلِكُ نَفْسَهُ عِنْدَ الْغَضَبِ»

**“The strong person is not the one who overpowers others; the strong person is the one who controls himself when angry.”**

Al-Bukhārī & Muslim

«لَا يَحِلُّ لِمُسْلِمٍ أَنْ يَهْجُرَ أَخَاهُ فَوْقَ ثَلَاثِ لَيَالٍ، يَلْتَقِيَانِ فَيُعْرِضُ هَذَا وَيُعْرِضُ هَذَا، وَخَيْرُهُمَا الَّذِي يَبْدَأُ بِالسَّلَامِ»

**“It is not lawful for a Muslim to shun his brother for more than three nights, each turning away when they meet. The better of the two is the one who greets first.”**

Al-Bukhārī & Muslim

«وَمَا زَادَ اللَّهُ عَبْدًا بِعَفْوٍ إِلَّا عِزًّا»

**“Allah does not increase a servant who pardons except in honour.”**

Muslim

**Notice:** The second hadith does not say the better one is the one who was wronged, but **the one who greets first**. Taking the first step is an honour, not a defeat.

FILE 05

# Our Role Model ﷺ

1

## A day harder than Uhud

ʿĀʾisha (may Allah be pleased with her) asked the Prophet ﷺ whether any day had been harder for him than the day of Uhud. He mentioned a day he invited the leaders of Thaqīf in Ṭāʾif and they rejected him. As he left in grief, the Angel of the Mountains called out, offering to crush them between two mountains. The Prophet ﷺ replied:

*"Rather, I hope that Allah will bring from their descendants people who worship Allah alone, associating nothing with Him."*

**Al-Bukhārī & Muslim**

**Lesson:** He had the power to take revenge, and chose hope for their guidance instead.

2

## The hanging sword

On one expedition the Prophet ﷺ slept under a tree and hung his sword on it. A man from the idolaters took the sword and said, "Who will protect you from me?" He ﷺ said, "Allah." The man sheathed the sword and sat down — and the Prophet ﷺ did not punish him.

**Al-Bukhārī & Muslim**

**Lesson:** He pardoned a man who wanted to kill him. What about someone who said a hurtful word?

FILE 06

# Forgiveness among the Companions

1

## Abu Bakr and Misṭaḥ

Abū Bakr (may Allah be pleased with him) used to support his poor relative Misṭaḥ. When Misṭaḥ joined those who spoke falsely about Abū Bakr's daughter ʿĀ'isha, Abū Bakr swore to stop. Then Allah revealed: "...and let them pardon and overlook. Would you not like that Allah should forgive you?" He said, "Yes, by Allah, I would love Allah to forgive me," and resumed supporting him.

**Al-Bukhārī**

**Lesson:** He forgave the hardest thing to hear: words against his own daughter's honour.

2

## ʿUmar and ʿUyayna

ʿUyayna ibn Ḥiṣn came to ʿUmar (may Allah be pleased with him), then Commander of the Believers, and said: "By Allah, you neither give us generously nor judge between us fairly!" ʿUmar grew so angry he was about to punish him. Al-Ḥurr ibn Qays said: "Allah told His Prophet: 'Take what is given freely, enjoin what is good, and turn away from the ignorant' — and this man is one of the ignorant." Ibn ʿAbbās said: by Allah, ʿUmar did not go beyond it once it was recited to him; he always stopped at the Book of Allah.

**Al-Bukhārī**

**Lesson:** At the height of his power, he stopped because he was reminded of one verse.

**Discuss with your classmates: why is pardoning harder when we are able to strike back?**

FILE 07

# Forgiveness & Mental Health

## What does the research say?

### Forgiveness programs ease distress

A systematic review and meta-analysis of randomised controlled trials: forgiveness interventions were linked to lower stress, anger and depression, and to more positive feelings.




Akhtar & Barlow (2018)

### A steady link with health

| 103 | 26,043 | 17 |
|---|---|---|
| samples | participants | countries |

Forgiveness is reliably linked to health — more strongly to mental than to physical health — with clear links to heart indicators such as heart rate and blood pressure.

Rasmussen et al. (2019)

### What about teenage girls?

In a study of adolescents aged 12–18, girls were more likely than boys to forgive others, and girls higher in **self-forgiveness** reported fewer depressive symptoms.

Kuzubova et al. (2021)

**Reading the science:** Evidence that forgiveness programs help is growing and consistent, but many studies are correlational or short-term. Forgiveness supports mental health; it does not replace getting help. If you feel low for a long time, the student counselor's door is open.

FILE 08

# Forgiveness Around the World

**16 November**

## International Day for Tolerance

Proclaimed by UNESCO's Member States in the 1995 *Declaration of Principles on Tolerance*, which states: "Tolerance is respect, acceptance and appreciation of the rich diversity of our world's cultures, our forms of expression and ways of being human."

UNESCO (1995)

## A global trial in five countries

Colombia · Hong Kong · Indonesia · South Africa · Ukraine

In a randomised controlled trial published in 2024, participants used a self-guided forgiveness workbook taking 2–3 hours. After just two weeks, their forgiveness rose and their depression and anxiety symptoms fell, compared with those still waiting their turn.

| 4,598 | 5 | 2–3 | 2 |
|---|---|---|---|
| participants | countries | hours | weeks to see an effect |

The drop in anxiety and depression was small but clear — a lot for such a short workbook.

Ho et al. (2024)

FILE 09

# Five Science-Tested Steps

These are the steps of the **REACH** model, developed by psychologist Everett Worthington — the same model used in the global trial:

**R**

### Recall the hurt calmly RECALL

Describe what happened as it was, without exaggerating and without blaming yourself.

**E**

### Step into her shoes EMPATHIZE

What might she have been going through? Understanding is not excusing.

**A**

### Give forgiveness as a gift ALTRUISTIC GIFT

Remember a time you were wrong and someone forgave you; give what you were given.

**C**

### Commit to your decision COMMIT

Write it down, or tell someone you trust: “I have decided to forgive.”

**H**

### Hold on to it HOLD ON

When anger returns, remember: a returning memory doesn't mean you didn't forgive.

FILE 10

# Two Voices Inside Me

In every hard moment two voices speak: the voice of anger and the voice of wisdom. Which one will you choose?

**1 A classmate posted a photo of you in the class group without asking.**

**Voice of anger**
I'll post an embarrassing photo of her in the same group.

**Voice of wisdom**
I'll talk to her privately, ask her to delete it, and accept her apology if she offers one.

**2 A friend shared a secret you trusted her with.**

**Voice of anger**
Our friendship is over. I'll never speak to her again.

**Voice of wisdom**
I'll tell her honestly my trust is shaken, and give her a chance — while being more careful what I share.

**3 A teammate didn't do her part of the group project, and your grade suffered.**

**Voice of anger**
I'll complain about her to everyone and never work with her again.

**Voice of wisdom**
I'll ask what happened, and next time we'll agree on a clear split of tasks.

**4 Your sister borrowed your things without asking and ruined one.**

**Voice of anger**
I'll take her things the way she took mine.

**Voice of wisdom**
I'll calmly tell her I'm upset, and we'll agree on an ask-first rule.

**Forgiveness doesn't erase boundaries:** you can forgive and, at the same time, set a new rule for how you are treated.

ACTIVITY 1

# Word Challenge

Twelve words are hidden in every direction — across, down and diagonal — and some are backwards. Can you find them all?

| J | J | L | L | Y | C | R | E | M | G | F | V |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| J | M | T | B | T | C | E | P | S | E | R | N |
| M | L | Y | H | T | A | P | M | E | R | O | H |
| H | A | G | E | N | T | L | E | H | D | A | R |
| E | C | N | E | I | T | A | P | R | R | K | W |
| R | C | H | V | S | F | V | A | M | R | I | S |
| R | I | W | I | J | T | P | O | H | F | N | A |
| V | M | T | G | L | M | N | U | F | U | D | P |
| N | L | A | R | W | Y | A | O | T | E | N | E |
| L | C | T | O | L | E | R | A | N | C | E | A |
| L | G | W | F | F | O | T | K | A | U | S | C |
| A | P | K | Y | I | E | I | S | L | Y | S | E |

- ☐ FORGIVE
- ☐ PARDON
- ☐ MERCY
- ☐ PATIENCE
- ☐ KINDNESS
- ☐ TOLERANCE
- ☐ PEACE
- ☐ RESPECT
- ☐ EMPATHY
- ☐ HARMONY
- ☐ GENTLE
- ☐ CALM

ACTIVITY 2

# Forgiveness in World Languages

Match each word meaning “forgiveness” to its language. Careful — some languages look very alike!

| WORD | LANGUAGE |
|---|---|
| Perdón | A Japanese |
| Perdono | B Korean |
| Vergebung | C Spanish |
| Bağışlama | D Russian |
| معافی | E German |
| بخشش | F Urdu |
| 宽恕 | G Persian |
| 許し | H Italian |
| 용서 | I Chinese |
| Прощение | J Turkish |

**Bonus: which two languages on this list are written in Arabic script?**

ACTIVITY 3

# The 7-Day Challenge

One small task a day. Tick it when it's done.

**Day 1** ☐
Be the first to greet someone you've drifted from.

**Day 2** ☐
Write down something that upset you, then tear up the paper.

**Day 3** ☐
Let a small slip pass without comment.

**Day 4** ☐
Apologise for a mistake you made, even a small one.

**Day 5** ☐
Make a kind duʿāʾ for someone who hurt you.

**Day 6** ☐
Praise a good quality in someone you disagree with.

**Day 7** ☐
Forgive yourself for an old mistake, and learn from it.

## My Pledge

**I, ....., choose to forgive, because forgiveness is my strength, not my weakness.**

Signature ..... Date .....

*“...and let them pardon and overlook.”*

**An-Nūr 24:22**

## Answer keys

### Word challenge

| J | J | L | L | Y | C | R | E | M | G | F | V |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| J | M | T | B | T | C | E | P | S | E | R | N |
| M | L | Y | H | T | A | P | M | E | R | O | H |
| H | A | G | E | N | T | L | E | H | D | A | R |
| E | C | N | E | I | T | A | P | R | R | K | W |
| R | C | H | V | S | F | V | A | M | R | I | S |
| R | I | W | I | J | T | P | O | H | F | N | A |
| V | M | T | G | L | M | N | U | F | U | D | P |
| N | L | A | R | W | Y | A | O | T | E | N | E |
| L | C | T | O | L | E | R | A | N | C | E | A |
| L | G | W | F | F | O | T | K | A | U | S | C |
| A | P | K | Y | I | E | I | S | L | Y | S | E |

### World languages

Perdón — Spanish

Perdono — Italian

Vergebung — German

Bağışlama — Turkish

معافی — Urdu

بخشش — Persian

宽恕 — Chinese

許し — Japanese

용서 — Korean

Прощение — Russian

**Urdu and Persian**

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